



TIME TO RELAX AND RECHARGE | EXERCISE 1

Breathwork

Breathwork and Meditation, including Mindfulness, are known to reduce stress, anxiety and depression, and to improve cognitive function including focus, memory, and attention span, as well as improved emotional regulation such as mood and self-awareness.

Breathing Techniques

Breathwork is the practice of intentional, controlled breathing which offers many physical, mental and emotional benefits through its influence on our autonomic nervous system. These include reduced stress and anxiety, enhanced focus and cognitive function (creativity, concentration, flow, memory, decision-making), improved mood, emotional regulation and self-awareness, all of which foster greater resilience and wellbeing. The exercises below provide an insight into how the power of breathing can help you relax, recharge and take back control of the way you think and feel.

Ideally when resting, your breath should be relaxed, inhaling through the nose, engaging the lower torso (and diaphragm) and exhaling



through the nose. Ideally each breath should be 'inhale for 5.5 seconds', 'exhale for 5.5 seconds' (coherent breathing).

This provides the optimum flow of oxygen to the cells, keeps your system balanced and eliminates toxins.

Technique 1: Box Breathing

Combat anxiety & stress,
improve flow

Anxiety and Stress activate the Sympathetic nervous system to increase heart rate, BP, breathing rate, sweating, as well as increased alertness and sensitivity to perceived threats.

Box breathing lowers the activity of the Sympathetic nervous system and stimulates the Parasympathetic nervous system, resulting in reduced physiological arousal, calming the mind and lowering stress.

This technique is used by individuals and teams, notable Navy SEALs, to stay calm and focused in tense situations.

Alternatives

If you find yourself feeling short of oxygen, reduce the timings to 3-3-3-3, and increase over time.

To relax more deeply to aid sleep vary the timings to 4-4-6-2 (Inhale-Hold-Exhale-Hold).



1. Inhale to a count of 4 through your nose, using your diaphragm and feeling your stomach rise.
2. Hold for a count of 4.
3. Breathe out through your nose for a count of 4.
4. Hold your breath for a count of 4.

Try to do this for around 4 minutes to reach a state of calm and flow.



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Technique 2:

4-7-8 Breath

To aid sleep/deep relaxation

This exercise puts the body into a state of deep relaxation and aids sleep. It activates the parasympathetic nervous system, helping you to wind down at the end of the day. It can be used to induce sleep or to help you go back to sleep:



1. Breathe in and then exhale with a 'whoosh' sound, this will place the tip of your tongue behind your front teeth.
2. With your mouth closed, inhale through your nose for a count of 4.
3. Hold the breath for a count of 7.
4. Exhale completely through pursed lips for a count of 8, relaxing your whole body.

Repeat 4-10 times.

Technique 3:

Jedi Breathing

To improve flow & focus

Jedi breathing /Alternate nostril breathing has balanced in and out breaths like Box Breathing, but you use alternate nostrils which forces you to concentrate even more. Use your thumb and ring finger to alternately close and release your nostrils.

Further Reading

Breath by James Nestor
ISBN:978-0-7352-1361-6

Breathe In Breathe Out by
Stuart Sandeman
ISBN:978-0-00-847537-6



1. Using the thumb and ring finger of your right hand, close your right nostril with your thumb and take an in-breath for 4.
2. Release the thumb/right nostril, close the left nostril with the ring finger, and breath out of the right nostril for 4.
3. Take an in-breath for 4 through your right nostril.
4. Close your right nostril with your thumb, release your left nostril and breath out of the left nostril for 4.

Repeat for up to 4 minutes to balance the 2 sides of the brain and the parasympathetic/sympathetic responses.

This requires all your concentration and allows you to break the cycle of overthinking and direct your focus.